

"What I Say, and What I Hold Back":

A Qualitative Study on Comparing Conflict with Friends and Parents

EDUC 5570 - Topics of Psychology in Education: Qualitative Studies of Developmental
Interventions

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Abstract

This qualitative study explores how Chinese international graduate students navigate interpersonal conflicts within two critical relational domains: parent–child relationships and peer friendships. Our research questions focus on four key issues: (1) How do conflicts arise in each relational domain? (2) What cultural, psychological, or structural factors trigger them? (3) Which coping strategies do students use, and how do these tactics differ between hierarchical family relationships and egalitarian friendships? and (4) What patterns of relational change emerge after conflict? Drawing on semi-structured interviews with first-year graduate students, the research examines the emotional, cultural, and strategic dimensions of conflict across these relationships. Findings reveal that conflict with parents is often shaped by hierarchical family dynamics and cultural values emphasizing filial piety, leading to strategies such as rational analysis, emotional suppression, and passive repair. In contrast, peer conflict tends to be more egalitarian and goal-oriented, involving direct communication, compromise, or strategic avoidance based on emotional safety and project goals. Emotional regulation emerged as a core mechanism in both domains but manifested differently depending on relational expectations. The study highlights the unique identity negotiations faced by international students as they reconcile collectivist cultural values with emerging individual autonomy. By illuminating the motivations, strategies, and emotional impacts of conflict, this research provides insights into the developmental significance of conflict and offers implications for culturally responsive educational and mental health support.

Introduction

Conflict is an inevitable part of interpersonal relationships. Whenever people differ—in values, communication styles, emotional habits, personal boundaries, or unspoken expectations—tension is bound to surface. On the surface, conflict may appear to signal discord or breakdown. But from a developmental perspective, it can also serve as a powerful catalyst for personal growth and deeper relational understanding.

Conflict becomes especially intense and complex when it occurs within close relationships—particularly with family member and friends—because these bonds involve a sense of belonging, long-term dependence, and mutual trust. For international students, the dynamics of conflict are even more layered. On one hand, they are immersed in the cultural environment of the host country; on the other, they remain influenced by the values and expectations of their culture of origin. Living in two cultural worlds at once, interpersonal conflict becomes more than just a momentary disagreement—it reflects broader shifts in identity, cultural cognition, and relational norms. In other words, conflict for international students often carries symbolic weight: it may represent tensions between competing cultural value systems, or signal a reevaluation of the boundaries and roles within their relationships.

One of the central premises of this study is that while conflict is often emotionally uncomfortable, it is not inherently negative. As Ames and Murray (1982) suggested, conflict can mark a developmental transition in a relationship, from superficial harmony to more authentic, emotionally resonant engagement. Rather than merely threatening relational stability, conflict may provide an opportunity to express unspoken needs, highlight boundaries, and redefine closeness. From this perspective, conflict is not the end of connection, but a potential way toward its revitalization.

This study focuses on how Chinese international students experience and navigate conflict within two of their most meaningful relational domains: family (specifically, parent–child relationships) and friendships. We aim to explore several core questions: How does conflict arise in these different types of relationships? What cultural, psychological, or structural factors trigger it? What strategies do students use to respond—and how do these strategies differ between parents and peers? What kinds of relational outcomes follow, and can we identify recurring patterns that cut across individual cases?

Our motivation for pursuing this topic stems not only from its research significance but also from its deep personal relevance. As Chinese students studying abroad, we have felt the strain these conflicts can create. On the one hand, our interactions with parents are often mediated by distance and technology—via video calls, voice messages, or text—rather than face-to-face encounters. This mode of communication, while convenient, often introduces emotional gaps or misinterpretations that make conflict harder to resolve. Meanwhile, with family physically far away, our friends take on an outsized emotional role, acting as companions and guides in our cultural adjustment and shaping our sense of belonging, identity, and everyday well-being (Razgulin et al., 2023). From our own experience, we have found that conflicts—whether with distant parents or close friends—are emotionally nuanced and rarely straightforward. Parent–child conflict often involves issues of responsibility, morality, and deeply held cultural values, while disagreements with friends tend to revolve around respect, reciprocity, and emotional support. This study grows out of our collective desire to better understand these relational tensions, and to offer insight to others who, like us, live between cultures and within emotionally demanding relational spaces.

Ultimately, we hope that by identifying the patterns, meanings, and coping strategies embedded in these conflicts, we can help make the experience of navigating close relationships—especially during times of disagreement—a little more visible, a little more nameable, and a little less isolating, perhaps help those going through conflict (or those who may face it in the future) feel a little less alone and confused, and a little more understood and empowered with choices.

Literature Review

Conflict in International Students

Recent research has increasingly focused on the challenges faced by international students as they adjust to new cultural environments. Much of this work has emphasized the stress associated with acculturation, language barriers, academic adjustment, and mental health concerns (Yoon et al., 2012; Smith & Khawaja, 2011). However, the relational dimension of cultural adaptation—particularly how international students experience and navigate conflict within their most intimate relationships—remains relatively underexplored. Among the limited studies that address this topic, some scholars have highlighted the critical role of peer relationships in supporting students' emotional well-being and sense of belonging (Razgulin et al., 2023). Given that international students are often unable to easily access family-based support networks, high-quality friendships become especially important, and particularly vulnerable to conflict.

Conflict with Parents vs. Conflict with Friends

Conflicts in friendships and those with parents differ not only in frequency or surface-level topics but also in the deeper mechanisms that generate them. In peer relationships, conflict is often triggered by unmet expectations of emotional reciprocity, violations of personal

boundaries, or mismatches in communication styles. These disagreements typically occur within an egalitarian structure and are generally addressed through negotiation, direct dialogue, or mutual compromise (Adams & Laursen, 2001; Hood et al., 2016). Because adult's friendships are voluntary and flexible, unresolved conflict may lead to distancing or even dissolution. While such conflicts can be emotionally painful or upsetting, they rarely result in severe or long-lasting consequences.

In contrast, conflict with parents is rooted in long-standing hierarchies of authority, emotional dependence, and cultural obligation. Particularly in Chinese families influenced by collectivist norms and Confucianism, parents often expect obedience, loyalty, and adherence to traditional family roles. When students exposed to Western cultural values begin to prioritize autonomy, expressive communication, and self-determined decision-making, the resulting tension often goes beyond specific disagreements—such as career paths or academic choices—and instead reflects deeper identity conflicts surrounding independence, duty, and intergenerational mismatch (Lai et al., 2023).

Emotional Regulation

Beyond structural and cultural differences, interpersonal conflicts elicit a range of emotional responses that profoundly influence individuals' psychological experiences and relational dynamics. In parent–child relationships, conflicts often evoke complex emotions such as guilt, shame, or feelings of betrayal, particularly when students perceive themselves as failing to meet parental expectations. These emotions may stem from cultural emphases on filial piety and familial obligations. Research indicates that parental experiences of trauma can intensify children's feelings of guilt and empathy towards their parents' suffering, potentially impacting their self-concept and future planning (Scarnier et al., 2009).

In contrast, conflicts among friends may lead to emotions like anger, disappointment, or insecurity regarding social acceptance, especially when individuals feel excluded or misunderstood. Such emotional responses can affect social decision-making and perceptions of fairness. Studies have shown that adolescents' responses to peers' emotional expressions, such as anger and disappointment, can influence their judgments in social interactions, highlighting the critical role of emotions in social dynamics (Delios et al., 2023). These emotional experiences not only affect memories of conflicts but also shape attitudes toward future interactions—leading to caution, avoidance, or increased openness (Dunn et al., 2022).

Resolution Strategies

In terms of conflict resolution, peer conflicts typically unfold within egalitarian power dynamics, where students tend to reach consensus through negotiation and mutual understanding. Moreover, the resolution of peer conflicts is often either cooperative or competitive, depending on the strength of the friendship and the individuals' interpersonal skills (Adams & Laursen, 2001).

In contrast, parent–child conflicts are generally embedded within hierarchical structures, where authority, obedience, and parental expectations dominate the interaction. A qualitative study of academic conflict in Chinese families by Ge and Tam (2021) found that parents often employed both overt and subtle forms of coercion, while adolescents responded with avoidance, compliance, or passive resistance—reflecting the complex tension between traditional values and youth autonomy. Similarly, Zhang (2007) reported that children raised in dialogue-oriented family environments were more likely to adopt collaborative or accommodating conflict styles, whereas those from obedience-oriented families were more inclined to use competitive or

avoidant strategies. These findings underscore the role of family communication patterns in shaping conflict resolution behaviors.

Outcomes

Multiple longitudinal studies have shown that unresolved parent–child conflict can lead to emotional distancing, erosion of trust, and diminished support within the relationship, along with sustained increases in internalizing problems such as depression and anxiety. Using two waves of data from the U.S. ABCD Study, Yang et al. (2023) found that higher levels of family conflict significantly predicted increased internalizing symptoms in adolescents one year later, even after controlling for neurobiological factors such as reward sensitivity. Similarly, in a three-year cohort study of 1,772 Chinese adolescents, Jin et al. (2025) found that family conflict not only correlated strongly with depressive symptoms but also created a bidirectional “conflict–depression” loop that further weakened emotional bonds between both mothers and sons, and fathers and sons. Additionally, Adams and Laursen (2007), in a community sample, reported that even moderate increases in conflict frequency—within already low-quality parent–child relationships—were associated with increased aggression and withdrawal, highlighting an amplifying effect of “poor relationship quality and conflict” on maladjustment.

In comparison, peer conflict is generally less frequent, shorter in duration, and more easily repaired through negotiation or apology. A systematic review by Alsarrani et al. (2022) found that high-quality friendships—characterized by trust, intimacy, and effective conflict management—are consistently linked with higher self-esteem, greater subjective well-being, and lower levels of depression. Furthermore, experimental work by Ehrlich et al. (2012) suggested that peer conflict alone does not predict impairments in social functioning; rather, adolescents facing high conflict in both friendships and parent relationships simultaneously are more likely

to exhibit aggression and delinquent behavior. This pattern suggests that peer conflict, in most cases, can serve as a developmental context for practicing negotiation and boundary setting. Supporting this view, Adams and Laursen (2007) also found that within high-quality friendships, moving from “no conflict” to “moderate conflict” was positively associated with academic achievement—reinforcing the idea that constructive conflict can promote both personal and relational development.

Methodology

Our study utilized a qualitative research design to explore the differences in resolution styles when individuals encounter conflicts with their peers versus parents. We aim to explore how these differences could influence personal development, emotional regulation, and relational well-being.

Participants

Participants were recruited from both offline recruitment and online posts, and were selected to be first-year graduate Chinese international students who had at least one conflict experience with both peers and parents gender balanced. All participants were over the age of 21 and were able to recall memories of conflicts with both peers and parents in the past two years.

Data Collection

Data was collected through semi-structured interviews in approximately 30-45 minutes. Each interview was conducted either in person or via Zoom, depending on the participants’ availability and preference. Considering participants’ comfort and language fluency, both interviewers and interviewees were using Mandarin. Before conducting interviews, an interview protocol was given to the interviewees to ensure the confidentiality of the contents. Our interview questions were designed by our research team, containing two major sections: conflict

with peers and conflict with parents. Both sections contain the same structure of questions. For each section, open-ended questions were asked in two criteria: 1) each individual's most representative past conflict, and 2) their overall conflict situations. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed by the interviewers. Transcripts were then translated into English and had all identity details removed, such as names and locations. Before starting the coding process, all transcripts were randomly shuffled, and each of our team members was assigned to code two transcripts that were not conducted by them to reduce potential bias.

Interview Questions

Our interview questions were designed to support the research goals outlined in our study. Based on our theoretical framework and literature review, we created the interviews to explore not only the occurrence of interpersonal conflict but also the deeper emotional and cultural dynamics that shape how conflicts are experienced, managed, and reflected. The questions were sequenced from a description to a reflection of conflict in order to gain insights about participants' emotional reaction and strategic reasoning. It allows us to understand how individuals process conflict from trigger to resolution, and also captures the emotional, relational, and cultural factors.

The parallel structure of peers and parents asking the same sets of questions about conflicts with both groups. We ask about initial reactions, emotional comfort in expression, resolution strategies, and post-conflict reflections in both cases. This would allow a direct comparison of conflict with both peers and parents. For instance, participants often reported a higher level of emotional suppression in conflicts with parents, particularly fathers, which aligns with hierarchical cultural expectations. On the other hand, peer conflicts usually involve more

negotiation and emotional openness. This contrast supports our goal of identifying how cultural values and unbalanced power were demonstrated in interpersonal conflict strategies.

Our design of interview questions also focuses on the role of emotion and how it shapes resolution strategy and the outcomes. Our questions highlight when and how participants “felt,” whether they were comfortable expressing emotion, and how emotion influenced their conflict goals and interpersonal behavior. This opens a space to explore how emotions may either boost or hinder effective resolution. Strong emotional expression may serve as relational repair by making vulnerability visible, while overwhelming emotion could disrupt resolution by intensifying tension. These emotional dynamics are important to understand the resolution outcomes and the participants’ internal narratives about the conflict. Through this lens, we begin to trace how emotion regulation habits and interpersonal expectations may shift across contexts.

In addition, our reflection questions (e.g., “Would you handle the conflict differently?”) further explore how participants learn from conflict. This part of the interview provides insight about strategies that were perceived as successful or regrettable, and why. Moreover, when comparing our coded themes with participants’ own retrospective evaluations, we can assess the alignment between behavioral data and self-awareness. This allows us to see not only what participants did or said, but also how they understand and frame those experiences.

Finally, our set of “general” questions provides contexts for individual narratives. By asking about typical conflict reasons, emotional tendencies, and cultural influences, we gather rich data across different cases and help explain individual differences. These questions also encourage participants to reflect on conflict patterns, which lead them to a broader self-concept and values. This “general” data is especially important for Chinese international students, whose transnational experiences may influence both their conflict expectations and resolution strategies.

Lastly, our design of interview questions enables us to investigate not just what participants say in conflict, but also what they feel, suppress, rationalize, and learn from it. This helps us to better understand how people navigate their most intimate disagreements and how those navigations reflect deeper truths about identity, agency, and adaptation.

Data Analysis

During the coding process, our team utilized a thematic coding approach. Each researcher read and re-read their assigned transcripts carefully to gain an in-depth understanding of the content first, and then initial codes were assigned to some recurring ideas and patterns from specific sentences and phrases from the texts (e.g., avoidance, direct argument), and each researcher gave their own definitions to these codes. After all researchers finish coding their assigned individual transcripts, all codes were put together in a shared codebook, and our team categorized similar codes into subcodes, which develop a larger concept of more focused categories (e.g., power dynamics). Our next step was to group all the subcodes into broader themes, which reflect broader patterns across the data (e.g., culture and values, emotional and psychological mechanisms). After all researchers reviewed and refined the themes, we made conclusions about the definitions and naming of each theme. By organizing our data into a codebook, we were able to conduct a clearer comparison between conflict with peers and parents.

Findings

Conflict with Parents

Strategic response

Strategic responses are actions taken by participants to manage or resolve conflicts with

parents. The participants either seem to avoid resolving the conflicts or they choose to resolve the problem using various methods.

Direct resolution

Participants, when involved in a conflict with parents, choose to face the conflict and think of various approaches to facilitate the resolution of the conflict.

Rational Analysis

Participants displayed distinct coping strategies when they had conflicts with parents. One of the most common strategies was rational analysis, where participants used logic, fact, and practical reasoning to persuade their parents. This approach often emerged in conflicts surrounding career choices or life planning, particularly when participants felt misunderstood or constrained by their parents' expectations. As one participant explained, 'I explained my concerns with realistic data, hoping they would listen.' This method reflects an effort to engage parents respectfully while asserting personal autonomy.

Information processing

Another widely used strategy was information processing, where participants gave their parents time and space to absorb new information and before reopening the discussion of disagreement. This approach minimized emotional escalation and allowed for more productive followup conversations. One participant described this as: 'I gave them time to digest information before having another serious conversation.'

Assertiveness

Some participants demonstrated assertiveness, directly expressing their needs and boundaries in a calm but firm manner. This was seen as a middle ground between confrontation and passivity. As one participant noted, ‘Directly express, because this matter is not indirect. It is a problem of either keeping it or not, and reading it or not.’ Assertiveness allowed them to communicate clearly without disrespecting parental authority.

Argument

In contrast, some participants addressed direct argument, engaging in emotionally charged or passionate discussion to defend their perspectives. While potentially confrontational, this strategy signaled a strong desire to be heard. One participant shared: ‘So I had a very reasonable and well grounded argument with her’, highlighting how arguments could still be structured and rational, even when emotionally intense.

Change of mindset

Other participants took a more reflective route, using a change of mindset to internally adjust their perspective and better tolerate or empathize with their parents. This strategy reflected emotional maturity and a desire to maintain family harmony. One participant explained, ‘I gradually adjusted my own mindset to try to understand my mother.’

Discuss afterwards

One strategy is to discuss afterwards, where participants choose to face the conflict, but with a delay until a calmer moment. This allowed for more constructive dialogue once tempers had cooled. As one participant noted, ‘It’s not the case when we are quarrelling, but perhaps when we are calm or chatting at some point, we might discuss this.’

Mutual compromise

In some cases, participants and their parents arrived at a mutual compromise, where both sides adjusted their expectations to find common ground. This approach fostered collaboration and mutual respect. One participant recounted, ‘although my mom said she couldn’t fully accept the ideas, it was a bit like both sides were taking a step back and finding a solution.’

Avoidance

However, not all responses were direct expressers. Some participants turned to avoidance, distancing themselves emotionally or physically from conflict. This strategy often stemmed from feelings of powerlessness or a desire to avoid futile arguments. One participant stated bluntly, ‘I think he’s crazy. Well, then I’d want to ignore him.’ Avoidance could serve as both a protective measure and a sign of disengagement.

Help-seeking

Lastly, some participants used help-seeking as a strategy, turning to external sources for guidance and reassurance. This included consulting friends, mentors, or people with similar experiences. One participant described this process by saying, ‘I might seek advice from others who have made decisions like me, ask them if they have any regrets about doing this?’ This strategy reflects a thoughtful and proactive approach to conflict resolution by gaining perspective from others outside the family.

Motivations Behind Strategies

This theme examines the underlying emotional and cognitive reasons why participants adopted particular strategies in resolving conflict with their parents. It highlights personal needs for emotional release, relational healing, and a desire for long-term stability or acceptance.

Emotional relief and expression

One core motivation was emotional relief and expression, where participants chose to express their frustrations in order to release pent-up emotions or push for change. This emotional drive often led to more open confrontation, even if it was charged with intensity. As one participant explained, ‘Maybe I could have been less emotional, but overall, expressing the issue helps. Expressing the issue helps bring change over time.’ For them, the emotional act of voicing conflict was not just cathartic, but strategic.

Desire for long-term security

Another common motivation was desire for long-term security, especially when conflict involved life decisions like education or career paths. Participants recognized that their parents’ seemingly restrictive views stemmed from a concern for safety and future well-being. One participant said, ‘To them, getting a degree felt more secure. I used their logic to convince myself.’ This reflects a complex negotiation between personal autonomy and internalized family values, driven by a sensible need to maintain stability and familial approval.

Need to avoid escalation or maintain peace

Participants were motivated by the need to avoid escalation or maintain peace. Particularly in families where parents were described as highly emotional or reactive, participants would suppress their own responses or withdraw from the conflict entirely to prevent

tension from intensifying. For instance, one participant explained, ‘Sometimes I do not say anything and just go to my room... my mom can be very emotional.’ Similarly, another said, ‘I just try to avoid conflict with my parents as much as I can.’ These reflect an internal balancing act between emotional regulation and relational preservation.

Relationship Repair Following Conflict

This theme explores how participants repaired or rebuilt their relationships with their parents after experiencing conflict. The repair processes were often gradual and emotionally intimate, involving increased empathy, communication, and emotional availability.

Improved mutual understanding

Others experienced improved mutual understanding as a direct result of conflict-related conversations. These were seen as transformative moments that shifted the emotional landscape of the relationship. One participant stated, ‘We got closer. These conversations built mutual trust and deeper understanding.’ In such cases, what initially appeared as rupture eventually became a foundation for stronger relational bond, especially when both sides were willing to listen and adapt.

Some participants described slow progress through vulnerability, where sustained tension eventually gave way to a deeper, more emotionally honest connection. Conflicts became an entry point into understanding one another better. As one participant noted, ‘Paradoxically, it brought us closer. We are learning to understand each other emotionally.’ This illustrates how vulnerability during conflict, while painful, can create room for mutual growth.

Passive repair

For some participants, repairing relationships with parents after conflict was a subtle and gradual process, often taking place without direct verbal resolution. One common method was passive repair, in which conflict was never explicitly discussed again, but the relationship slowly returned to normal through resumed daily interactions. As one participant described, ‘We just start talking again normally... like nothing happened.’ Others may take longer times, in these situations, reconciliation was not immediate and sometimes took days or even weeks to occur. One participant recalled, ‘It took us weeks to talk again... but we did not really address it.’ These forms of passive or delayed repair highlight how parent-child relationships may be maintained through emotional distance or implicit forgiveness, rather than through direct discussion.

Emotional and Psychological Mechanism

This theme addresses how participants processed, regulated, and expressed their emotional experiences during conflict with parents. These internal dynamics were shaped by expectations of emotional support, intergenerational misunderstandings, and personal growth.

Frustration and vulnerability

Many participants described episodes of frustration and vulnerability, often when parents failed to validate their emotions or lived experiences. These moments exposed emotional gaps in the parent-child relationship. One participant shared, ‘Anger. I thought, you are older than me, and I still have to teach you how to express emotions healthily?’ This reflects the emotional burden some participants carried, especially when they felt more emotionally literate than their parents.

Resentment and emotional distance

In some cases, repeated emotional disconnection leads to restatement and gradual emotional distancing. When participants felt their needs were routinely ignored or criticized, they began to withhold emotional openness as a form of protection. One participant noted, 'I just stopped telling them things after that. It was not worth the stress.' This pattern reflects the long-term psychological consequences of unresolved family conflict, particularly the erosion of trust and openness.

Suppressing own emotional reactions

At the same time, some participants coped by reframing their parents' behavior or suppressing their own emotional reactions. Rather than confront conflict directly, they mentally shifted their perspective to reduce emotional pain. For example, one participant explained, 'It is just how they are... I don't take it personally anymore.' This form of emotional regulation combines reappraisal and suppression. It allowed participants to maintain peace without constant confrontation, though often at the cost of emotional closeness.

Culture and values

Cultural norms and value systems deeply influenced how participants navigated conflict with their parents. A central theme was the tension between filial piety, rooted in collectivist values, and desire for personal autonomy, more common in individualistic cultures.

Obligation to respect and obey

Many participants described a strong sense of obligation to respect and obey their parents, even when they disagreed. This often led to internal conflict between honoring family expectations and asserting their own needs or beliefs. As one participant described, 'I feel guilty

when I push back... even if I know I am right, I do not want to upset them.’ This illustrates how cultural expectations of deference and family harmony could override personal boundaries.

Actively challenged the different value

Participants with bicultural or Western-leaning backgrounds sometimes actively challenged these values, though not always without hesitation. Some struggled with guilt or confusion when asserting independence, particularly around education, relationships or emotional expression. For example, one participant reflected, ‘I want to be honest with them, but I also know they won’t understand because of how they grew up.’ This highlights the emotional cost of navigating two cultural frameworks, one that prioritizes obedience, and one that encourages open communication and self-expression.

Strategically blend cultural values

Others learned to strategically blend cultural values, using respectful language or indirect communication as a compromise. For instance, rather than openly confronting their parents, participants often chose to reason through practical examples or delay difficult conversations until emotions had settled. One participant shared, ‘I waited a few days and then explained things in a way they could accept. I did not want them to feel disrespected.’ This strategy reflects an effort to uphold filial norms while still advocating for oneself, which is a form of culturally sensitive negotiation.

Cultural differences

Moreover, cultural differences also shaped emotional expression and suppression. Several participants noted that in their family, emotional conversations were seen as ‘too much’ or

‘unnecessary’, especially by older generations. As one person said, ‘My parents think talking about feelings is weak. That is just not how they were raised.’ This perspective reveals how cultural stigma around emotional vulnerability can inhibit conflict resolution and deepen generational divides.

Conflict with Peers

Strategic Responses

Strategic responses are actions taken by participants to manage or resolve conflicts with peers. The participants either seem to avoid resolving the conflicts or they choose to resolve the problem using various methods.

Avoidance

Avoidance is when participants choose not to express themselves when a disagreement exists. In other words, they choose not to externalize the disagreement by expressing disagreement that causes an explicit conflict of two opinions, making sure only one opinion exists even though that opinion is opposed to the participants’ interest, and the participants are able to bear with that influence. When there is no explicit collision of two opinions, there will be no need to resolve it. One participant shared, “I didn’t take the initiative to raise my complaints,” highlighting their reluctance to voice issues. Another added, “I think my personality, I am not a person who likes to initiate conflict,” suggesting a general disposition toward withdrawal. When encountering incompatible personalities, one participant stated, “If it is given to a person who is not compatible with me, for example, in personality or behavior... I’ll probably start to care less about him/her.” Rather than confronting the issue, they found it easier to withdraw emotionally.

Others dealt with conflict by staying silent, as in: “Otherwise I would tell my friends or parents... but I have never, basically, told her about these things,” and “I haven't told her... so I just choose to endure it.” Even logistical incompatibility led to internalized stress, with one participant saying, “Her schedule is completely opposite to mine... I don't want to tell her, so I'll just accept that I'm not lucky and bear it myself.”

Direct Communication

On the other hand, some participants choose to put out different opinions, and use various methods to reach a consensus, even though the onset of such direct communications can differ in timing, some communicate immediately while others communicate later. For example, one participant said, “We had some public discussions, so we understand each other better. So it is equivalent to resolving this conflict.” Another stated, “We didn't resolve conflict when it happens... until after it's over,” showing the variation in timing. Directness was seen as a method to reduce misunderstandings: “The way of expressing oneself candidly is quite effective, because I think many times misunderstandings arise conflicts between friends.” In team settings, a rational approach was emphasized: “I think as a team, we should finish the goal, so we should sit down and open this matter first, and talk clearly.”

Rational Analysis

To be more specific, some prefer using logic and structured discussion to address differences, this method allows mutual understanding and agreement by perceiving the disagreement as one step of the problem solving process. One participant reflected on her experience by saying, “We listed the pros and cons of both proposals,” which demonstrates how objectivity can structure resolution. Public discussion also played a role in this strategy: “Public

discussion was used to clarify viewpoints more efficiently.”

Merge of Opinions

During discussions, some participants also try to combine different opinions into one, this way, disagreement will be eliminated. One participant expressed this approach with, “I can change my part according to their existing model,” indicating a willingness to adapt and integrate.

Compromise

Another approach is reaching an agreement through mutual concessions, this not only shows a respectful attitude, but also helps reaching a balanced decision. One participant noted, “The other party proposed a compromise solution, and I was willing to make concessions too,” showing both sides’ involvement in maintaining balance.

Help-seeking

On the other hand, rather than resolving the conflict within the group, seeking intervention from a neutral figure like a teacher seems to mediate the conflict. One participant described, “So I asked the professor, and then I checked online by myself to find out how to adjust it better,” demonstrating a proactive, yet external, method of conflict management.

Motivations Behind Strategic Responses

Participants described a range of motivations that influenced how they approached and responded to conflict. These motivations shaped their choices in either avoiding confrontation or addressing conflict constructively.

Goal-Oriented

Several participants choose to avoid or confront because there is an important goal for them to achieve, avoiding or confronting seem to be a conscious choice by them in order to achieve that goal.

Prioritizing Project Completion

One goal is that participants expressed a strong desire to maintain peer group productivity and ensure the project stayed on track, even if that meant avoiding deeper interpersonal issues. As one explained, “I felt anxious about project progress,” and another said, “We didn’t want small disputes to hinder the overall work.”

Avoid Escalating the Conflict

In some cases, participants aimed to prevent minor disagreements from escalating, such goals sometimes frame the resolution strategy to early clarification of viewpoints that avoid misunderstandings among peers, but could also make participants hesitant when expressing opinions. One noted, “We clarified each other’s viewpoints more efficiently to avoid unnecessary conflicts,” while another expressed concern, saying, “I wonder if I just say it, will it make things worse?”

Saving Time and Energy When Confrontation Has No Meaning

Sometimes, a conflict exists between peers and bothers the participants. However, there are barely any benefits to resolve the conflict and reach a consensus, for example, not a significant relationship or no mutual goals. Avoiding interactions saves time and energy for

participants and brings the greatest benefits. As one participant put it, “Respect is mutual. If I feel I’m not respected, I will take the initiative to avoid or stay away.” Others said, “Unless it is a special relationship that cannot be separated, there’s no need to compromise or try to change,” and “If it means saving energy, then avoidance works.” One even admitted, “I didn’t expect much from the relationship...”

Personal Well-being and Safety

Some participants prioritized their own emotional or mental health, withdrawing from peer conflict when it began to impact their well-being. One explained, “It might have some influence on my life or study state,” and another shared, “In a situation where my own study and life conditions are not very good...” Others highlighted safety concerns, saying, “I chose emotional self-protection,” and “I’m afraid she will do something extreme... so I’ll just have to endure it.” The gravity of the situation was further illustrated: “Her screams are not ordinary screams... they are very scary, I really don’t dare to tell her,” and “I’m afraid she is a very extreme person.”

Emotion as Guidance

On the other hand, emotions could guide strategies in a reflexive manner.

Belief in Personal Integrity

Participants who believed they had not done anything wrong often felt confused and angry, leading them to emotionally withdraw or lash out. One remarked, “I thought that I didn’t do anything wrong... I would feel very unfair and confused.” Another confessed, “I was angry... I might have vented my emotions on the person who made me angry.” This emotional toll was

compounded by feelings of exclusion: “His doing this really hurt me and made me feel excluded.”

Frustration and Anxiety

Emotional reactions such as frustration and anxiety also influenced conflict behavior. One participant noted, “I felt very frustrated because my plan was not accepted,” while another said, “I was worried about the project’s progress being delayed.” There was also a sense of moral responsibility: “I felt obligated to explain why his words were offensive.”

Relationship Repair Following Conflict

Participants took various paths after a conflict occurred, ranging from disengaging from the relationship to actively repairing and maintaining it.

Disengagement & Surface-Level Maintenance

Some chose to maintain a polite but distant peer relationship, no longer considering the person a close friend. For example, “We barely maintained a surface-level friendship,” and “He is someone I can hang out with, but not my close friends.” Though discussions continued, perspectives shifted: “We had more discussions—but I viewed him differently from then on.” This sometimes resulted in emotional loss: “Maybe we both lost a good friend.”

Understanding and Reconciliation

Others expressed empathy and attempted to maintain or even strengthen peer friendships after conflict resolution. One participant shared, “His original intention was from a good starting point... it felt like a misunderstanding.” This led to positive outcomes: “After we resolved this,

we remained very good friends.” The significance of friendship was emphasized: “Friends still hold a rather important position in my life,” and “Everyone has made it smoothly and has not slowed this pace due to obstructions.”

Emotional and Psychological Mechanisms

Emotions not only play a role in triggering conflicts and shaping resolution strategies, but also as a factor that facilitates or disrupts the resolving process depending on whether the emotions are expressed or not, and how they are expressed.

Nonverbal Anger

Some participants express frustration nonverbally, using obvious body language and strange tones that show their peers that something is wrong. However, the passive aggressiveness may provoke other’s emotions and disrupt the process of solving the conflict. One noted, “I was acting very passive aggressive,” while another said, “I will express them in a very obvious way... use some expressions or attitudes to express my negative emotions.”

Verbal Anger and Emotional Outbursts

Others resorted to verbal venting to release frustration, expressing emotion using language and angry tones to their peers, even if it wasn’t intended to resolve the conflict. One recalled, “It was a bit like an outbreak,” and another admitted, “I might have said some irrational words.” Despite the tension, one participant noted, “At the moment I said it, I felt much better.”

Emotional Regulation

Some participants, especially those concerned about project outcomes, hid emotions for

the sake of cooperation between peers. Such control of impulse seems to be a rational decision to facilitate achieving the goal of resolving the conflict, helping to maintain a rational fluent resolving communication process. One participant said, “I feel I cannot express my emotions freely to a certain extent,” and another reflected, “Maybe it stabilized my emotions.” Others allowed time to pass before responding constructively: “After calming down for a few days, I initiated a rational discussion.”

Culture values and Communication Norms

The final theme relates to participants’ reflections on cultural norms and values that influenced their approach to peer conflict.

Preference for Directness

In the communication practice of some cultures, directness is emphasized for the sake of transparency during communications. Some participants explicitly valued direct communication as a preferred and common method adopted in their contexts to deal with disagreement. One stated, “With peers, it’s better to be direct — if it doesn’t work, it’s fine to part ways.” Another added, “When doing tasks with peers, I prefer direct confrontation and third-party judgment if necessary.”

Discomfort with Emotional Expression

For some local cultures in China, people would consider more before direct emotional expressions due to various cultural and historical reasons. Hence, among those individuals, directness in emotions during conflicts could be limited during hesitancy and ambiguity. As one participant mentioned, “Expressing emotions felt uncomfortable.” Another stated, “I naturally

adopted an indirect style to avoid direct confrontations.”

Discrepancies in communication styles

As cultures and experiences could put emphasis on different communication styles, according to some participants, it led to misalignment. As one explained, “Everyone has different styles... they may accidentally speak in a way that is not so nice.”

Discussion

This study explored how Chinese international students navigate conflict in two key relational contexts—peer and parent relationships—and identified significant differences in resolution styles, emotional experiences, and cultural influences. Through thematic analysis of interview data, we gained important understandings about the psychological and relational mechanisms that underlie conflict coping strategies in intercultural and intergenerational contexts.

Comparative Patterns in Conflict Coping Strategies

A central finding of this study is that conflict resolution with parents tends to reflect hierarchical family dynamics shaped by collectivist cultural values, whereas conflict resolution with peers often occurs in more egalitarian and goal-oriented contexts. Participants facing parental conflict frequently used strategies such as rational analysis, information processing, and assertiveness, but they also employed avoidance or internal reframing to maintain family harmony. These approaches reveal a careful balancing act between asserting autonomy and fulfilling filial obligations. In contrast, peer conflict was approached with more flexibility, ranging from avoidance in emotionally distant relationships to direct communication, compromise, or third-party help-seeking in goal-driven contexts.

Interestingly, both relational contexts showed patterns of emotional regulation, but with different emphases. In parent-child conflict, emotion was often suppressed or reappraised to avoid escalating conflict and preserve long-term connection. In peer conflict, participants described using emotional regulation to achieve mutual benefit or personal well-being. These findings reveal how power dynamics and relationship expectations shape not only behavioral responses but also internal emotional strategies.

Cultural Influence and Identity Negotiation

Consistent with previous research (Lai et al., 2023), participants' strategies reflected the tension between collectivist and individualist cultural norms. Many participants struggled to reconcile the traditional values in collectivist cultures, which expect respect, care, and obedience towards parents and emotional restraint, with their growing identification with Western values emphasizing autonomy and directness. Some found ways to strategically blend both value systems by using culturally sensitive communication techniques to reduce friction and maintain respect.

In peer conflict, cultural norms around communication and confrontation were also evident, but participants often felt more empowered to choose resolution styles aligned with their personal preferences. This flexibility suggests that intercultural conflict with parents may involve more identity negotiation, as it challenges deeply ingrained norms and emotional scripts.

Emotional and Psychological Mechanisms

Emotional responses played a dual role in conflict resolution. On one hand, emotions such as frustration, resentment, and anxiety often triggered conflict or shaped avoidance strategies. On the other hand, when expressed thoughtfully, emotional vulnerability served as a pathway to

deeper mutual understanding, particularly in parental relationships. Notably, participants who experienced emotional disconnection from parents described long-term effects such as reduced openness and trust. Meanwhile, peer conflict appeared to be more contained: participants either repairing the relationship or redefining its importance in their social lives.

These findings support previous literature on emotion regulation in conflict (Hood et al., 2016) and extend it by showing how emotional expression and suppression differ depending on the relational and cultural context. Moreover, they underscore the role of conflict as both a rupture in a relationship and an opportunity for psychological growth and emotional clarity.

Implications for Practice and Future Research

The findings of this study emphasize the importance of understanding conflict resolution as a culture and context-sensitive process, particularly for Chinese international students navigating multiple relational spheres. In interactions with parents, participants often found themselves caught between traditional expectations of respect and obedience and their growing desire for autonomy, which could be viewed as an emotional tension that calls for culturally sensitive mental health support. Therapists and counselors working with this population may need to help students process not only the content of conflicts, but also the cultural and emotional meanings attached to them. Therapeutic approaches that validate both filial values and emerging individual needs could better support students in navigating these complex family dynamics.

Within peer relationships, conflict was approached with greater behavioral flexibility. It was often driven by practical concerns such as task completion, emotional safety, or group harmony. These patterns suggest opportunities for educators and academic advisors to intentionally foster environments that encourage healthy communication and collaborative problem-solving.

Structured group activities, reflective exercises on communication styles, and workshops on emotional intelligence could help students gain confidence in expressing disagreement while maintaining respect and empathy.

In family contexts, the findings of this study may help bridge generational and cultural divergence. Many students internalized the emotional consequences of conflict with parents, often choosing silence or avoidance out of guilt or fear of escalating conflict. In light of this, parent-focused outreach programs could provide valuable context for families to better understand their children's developmental transitions and emotional needs while abroad, possibly through university-hosted webinars or cross-cultural family education sessions.

This study also invites researchers to expand the scope of conflict resolution studies to include cultural frameworks, relational hierarchies, and emotional regulation strategies. Conflict is not a uniform experience; it is shaped by who the other party is, the cultural values that frame the interaction, and the emotional goals of the individual. Future work could build on these findings by examining how different cultural groups navigate conflict across various types of relationships, especially over time or in response to shifting social environments.

Limitations

While this study offers varied perspectives into the lived experiences of conflict among Chinese international students, several limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings.

First of all, the sample was relatively small and drawn from a single university, which limits the generalizability of the results to broader populations. Expanding the participant pool to

include students from different educational institutions or cultural backgrounds could offer a more comprehensive understanding of how conflict coping varies across contexts.

The reliance on participants' recollection of past experiences may also introduce recall bias. Participants were asked to reflect on past conflicts, which may have been shaped by selective memory, emotional filtering, or social desirability in retelling sensitive experiences. This means that the narratives shared might reflect not just what happened, but also how participants have come to make sense of those events over time.

Translation and interpretation pose another potential limitation. Although interviews were transcribed and translated with care, some cultural nuances may have been lost or altered in the process, particularly around emotion, tone, or indirect communication. These subtleties are especially important when dealing with themes like emotional suppression or indirect negotiation, which are common in East Asian communication styles.

Finally, the cross-sectional design offers a brief glimpse rather than a complete developmental trajectory. Conflict styles and emotional responses may shift over time, especially as students continue to adapt to their host cultures or undergo personal development. Future research could conduct longitudinal studies to help trace these changes and explore the long-term impact of conflict experiences on emotional well-being and identity formation.

Conclusion

This study provides a meaningful and informative understanding of how Chinese international students navigate the emotional and relational complexities of conflict with both parents and peers. While peer conflict tended to be addressed with strategies aimed at

maintaining group functionality and emotional safety, parental conflict was more deeply shaped by cultural expectations, emotional vulnerability, and identity negotiation.

The findings reveal a portrait of individuals striving to balance respect with self-expression, harmony with authenticity, and connection with autonomy. In this context, conflict is not simply a problem to be solved: it is also a site of growth, emotional reckoning, and relational recalibration. Whether through direct communication, strategic avoidance, or reflective mindset shifts, the participants in this study revealed how deeply conflict resolution is linked to the ongoing process of cultural, emotional, and personal development. Through the exploration of these diverse strategies and motivations, this study offers a more holistic interpretation of conflict not just as rupture, but as an opportunity for learning and transformation. Also, in efforts to support diverse student populations, the practical guidance provided in this paper may contribute to the development of empathy, effective communication, and emotional adjustment.

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Appendix I: Interview Questions

Interview Questions:

1. Can you describe the most representative conflict (in 2 years) you had with **friends around your age**?
 - Can you describe a recent conflict you had with a peer?
 - What was it about?
 - Is the person the same or different gender?
 - What was your initial reaction when the conflict started?
 - Did you attempt to resolve the conflict?
 - If yes, how did you resolve it?
 - Did you and your peer openly discuss the issue, or was it resolved more indirectly? Why?
 - If no, why did you choose not to attempt to resolve the conflict?
 - How did you feel during and after the conflict?
 - Did you feel comfortable expressing your emotions in the conflict? Why or why not?
 - How did your peer respond to the conflict, and how did that affect your reaction?
 - Did you seek advice from anyone before or after handling the conflict?
 - If so, who and why?
 - Looking back
 - Looking back, do you think your chosen conflict resolution strategy was effective? Why or why not?
 - If you could go back, would you handle the conflict differently? Why or why not?
 - How do you think this conflict affected your relationship with your peer afterward?

General in peers

- What are the most common reasons for conflicts with your peers (e.g., cultural misunderstandings, academic stress, personal space, communication differences)?
 - How comfortable are you with expressing disagreement or criticism to your peers? What factors influence your decision?
 - How do conflicts with peers typically make you feel (e.g., stressed, indifferent, frustrated)?
2. Can you describe the most representative conflict (in 2 years) you had with your **parents**?
- Can you describe a recent conflict you had with a parent?
 - Is this with your mother or father?
 - What was it about?
 - What was your initial reaction when the conflict started?
 - Did you attempt to resolve the conflict?
 - If yes, how did you resolve it?
 - Did you and your parents openly discuss the issue, or was it resolved more indirectly? Why?
 - If no, why did you choose not to attempt to resolve the conflict?
 - How did you feel during and after the conflict?
 - Did you feel comfortable expressing your emotions in the conflict? Why or why not?
 - How did your parents respond to the conflict, and how did that affect your reaction?
 - Did you seek advice from anyone before or after handling the conflict?
 - If so, who and why?
 - Looking back
 - Looking back, do you think your chosen conflict resolution strategy was effective? Why or why not?
 - If you could go back, would you handle the conflict differently? Why or why not?
 - How do you think this conflict affected your relationship with your parent afterward?

General in parents

- What are the most common reasons for conflicts with your parents (e.g., career expectations, academic choices, independence, cultural differences)?
 - How comfortable are you with expressing disagreement or criticism to your peers? What factors influence your decision?
 - How do conflicts with your parents typically make you feel? Do they feel different from conflicts with peers?
3. In general, do you think you tend to handle conflicts differently with peers compared to parents? Why or why not? (hint: like values, culture, family style, or your personality)

Appendix II: Codebook

Conflict with Parents			
Overarching Code	Subcode	Definition	Coded Text / Examples
1. Causes of Conflict <i>Definition: The background and reasons for the emergence of conflict.</i>			
1.1	Lifestyle Values	Conflict caused by differing views on appropriate daily routines and time management	1. "My mother expected me to wake up at 5 or 6 am to run, but I preferred sleeping until 10 am on weekends." 2. "We clashed because she could not understand why I wouldn't adopt her early-morning routine."
1.2	Life Decisions	Conflicts arising from major life choices such as career, academic stress, and marriage/childbearing.	1. "The conflicts were about finding a job, academic stress, and having a baby." 2. "Instead of supporting me with job-related anxiety, my parents lectured me and blamed me for not working hard enough." 3. "My father asked when I planned to marry, causing tension as I wasn't prepared to think about marriage yet." 4. "There was a dispute over career choice." 5. "My father opposed my choice of a stable field; he had different ideas." 6. "My parents' expectations about marriage significantly differed from my own plans." 7. "He pushed back, saying a master's degree could still be helpful."

1.3	Intergenerational Values	Conflicts resulting from differences in generational values.	1. "My parents didn't believe the difficulties I described and didn't allow me to express upset emotions." 2. "My parents thought I should already be dating or married, but I felt it was premature considering my current situation."
1.4	Excessive Parental Control	Conflicts caused by parents excessively interfering and controlling personal space.	1. "My parents implicitly pushed me to date and get married, which made me outraged." 2. My mother has a relatively strong sense of possession, not just possessiveness, but a strong desire to control. This leads to all kinds of situations where she wants to control me, but if I get out of her control, some conflicts occur, these might include what time I got home, and then my... Even including my choice of breakfast.
1.5	Parents absence and emotional distance	physical absence of parents lead to emotional distance	1. My dad was a workaholic, and he worked when he came home. And he leaves early in the morning, so in fact, we barely communicate with each other
1.6	Emotional Expression Expectations	Conflict due to differences in expressing emotions.	1. His unhealthy way of expressing emotions hurt those around him.
1.7	Distancing from parents	Long-term physical separation normalizes emotional distance.	1. Because I have been studying abroad for a very long time, I have probably been alone outside for eight or nine years. In fact, I usually contact my parents very little, so we are still more used to such a life that I am not home with them.
2. Strategic responses <i>Definition: Actions taken by participants to manage or resolve conflicts with parents</i>			

2.1	Post-Conflict Written Communication	Sending messages to apologize and explain feelings after initial emotional outbursts.	1. "After our online argument, I sent her a message explaining my thoughts and apologizing for my tone." 2. "I told her I appreciated her intentions but needed personal flexibility." 3. I wrote a long letter to my mom.
2.2	Good Intentions	Recognizing and affirming the positive intentions behind parents' expectations.	1. "I said, 'I know you want the best for me,' even while expressing my own needs."
2.3	Direct Expression	Expressing dissatisfaction and emotional struggles directly during conflict.	1. "During the argument, I directly told her that waking up early every day was too hard for me." 2. "I cursed at her and tried to persuade them logically, but they refused to listen." 3. But perhaps I think something like simple personal interest or hobby, her interference of these would make me very angry, and that's why I had a big quarrel with her 4. So I had a very reasonable and well-grounded argument with her. 5. Yes, always very directly. 6. I often talk to my mom about it. 7. We laid out our views clearly. 8. They started talking more often about my future plans...
2.4	Rational Analysis	Using data, real-world facts, and logical reasoning to persuade parents.	1. "I hoped they would patiently listen to my concerns and use real-world data to persuade them." 2. "I explained my concerns with realistic data, hoping they would listen."

			3. "I explained that due to my academic and career situation, I truly had no time to consider marriage."
2.5	Seeking Intermediary Support	Using other family members for emotional buffering and advice.	1. "I preferred discussing issues with my aunt, who provided understanding without anxiety." 2. I communicated through my older sister and let her relay the message to them. 3. I might seek advice from others who have made decisions like me, ask them if they have any regrets about doing this?
2.6	Information Processing	Giving parents space and time to digest new information before resuming discussion.	1. "I gave them time to digest information before having another serious conversation."
2.6	Avoidance	Avoiding in-depth discussions or deflecting the topic to minimize conflict.	1. "I entered a cold war with my parents, avoiding deep conversations and not actively sharing life details." 4. "I typically ended conversations with my mom quickly to avoid deeper arguments." 5. "I chose brief responses like 'I'm tired, going to sleep now' to close stressful discussions." 6. I think he's crazy. Well, then I'd want to ignore him. 7. We didn't work it out, because my dad usually just came over, gave me a preach, and left 8. I packed my things and just left.
2.7	Change of mindset	participants tried to change their own mindsets to understand their parents	1. I think instead of solving problems, it's more like adjusting my mindset. 2. I gradually adjusted my own mindset to try to understand my mother, and maybe for me, I can feel my mother

2.8	Discuss Afterwards	Participants prefer to discuss after the conflict as a strategy when conflicting with parents.	1. It's not the case when we are quarrelling, but perhaps when we are calm or chatting at some point, we might discuss this.
2.9	Assertiveness	Expressing one's needs and opinions clearly and respectfully without aggression.	1. Directly express, because this matter is not indirect. It is a problem of either keeping it or not, and reading it or not.
3. Motivations behind strategies <i>Definition: Reasons why participants choose certain ways to handle conflict</i>			
3.1	Parental Support	Seeking long-term approval and understanding rather than winning a single argument.	1. "It's necessary to calmly express ideas and seek parental acceptance." 2. "I wanted them to realize that my choice was based on rational thinking, not impulsiveness."
3.2	Family Harmony	Seeking to maintain a peaceful relationship through calm post-conflict communication.	1. "I didn't want the misunderstanding to deepen, so I explained myself clearly afterward." 2. "I realized my mom was expressing anxiety, not necessarily pushing me, so I managed conversations carefully." 3. To them, getting a degree felt more secure.
3.3	Mutual Understanding	Wanting both sides to understand and respect each other's perspectives	1. "I wanted her to realize I respected her habits but also needed my own pace." 2. "I just wanted them to understand me quickly." 3. They did give me some practical reasons—like finances and job-hunting timeline. 4. Expressing the issue helps bring change over time.

3.4	Self-protection	Choosing limited communication afterward to avoid emotional damage.	1. "I evaluate whether a situation will induce conflict; if potentially harmful, I avoid discussing it." 2. "I didn't want to escalate the situation or stress myself further, so I used quick, neutral responses."
3.5	Desire for autonomy	That person values making their own choices rather than conforming to others' expectations.	1. I didn't choose their path to do it, so I couldn't sacrifice my consciousness to get close to their will.
4. Relationship repair following conflict <i>Definition: Actions taken by participants to restore trust, understanding, and emotional connection between parents after a conflict</i>			
4.1	Emotional Awareness	Developing better emotional communication patterns through conflict resolution.	1. "Through conflicts like this, I learned to be more rational when dealing with emotions." 2. "My mother also learned to express herself more calmly."
4.2	Deepened Understanding	Honest communication led to greater empathy and fewer future conflicts.	1. "Afterward, there were fewer conflicts about daily schedules." 2. "We both became more willing to listen and understand each other." 3. Our relationship didn't change much... but we might understand each other better now. 4. These conversations built mutual trust and deeper understanding. 5. Know me more, and then respect my decisions more 6. They will feel that I have my ideas about handling things, and then I can also take on the responsibility of being an adult.

4.3	Stable Family Relationship Maintenance	Maintaining a strong parent-child bond despite the conflict.	1. "The conflict did not affect my relationship with my parents." 2. "After communicating rationally, they reluctantly agreed to support me." 3. "The conflict wouldn't cause me to hate them or permanently estrange myself from them." 4. After a few days... we made up again.
4.4	Change Communication strategy	Adjust communication style for effective communication and avoid further conflict.	1. "I selectively share harmless things with my parents afterward." 2. "I selectively chose which issues to discuss to avoid triggering parental anxiety." 3. "After cooling down for a few days, I switched to a rational, fact-based discussion." 4. We're learning to understand each other emotionally.
4.5	Resistance to parental Control	Participants resists parental control and responds with emotional detachment	1. Even if he didn't let me play, I wouldn't just stop, and he couldn't just say he came and took my computer away. None of this, at least none of this is gonna happen. So if he wants to grumble and I'll let him grumble.

4.6	Long-lasting Effects	Conflict still affects the relationship between participants and parents.	1. These problems objectively exist, and then... Just... It has always somewhat affected our relationship 2. In terms of the outcome, there's no effect at all, because I think even today, if I suddenly start painting at home, my mom might still use similar reasons to have a conflict with me. 3. So I think this has caused me a kind of trauma. It makes me think that my mother has an extremely excessive desire for control, and then in this way I feel that no matter how reasonable what I do is, it gives me a little... No matter how you put it, I still live in some rather gloomy states.
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5. Emotional and psychological mechanisms

Definition: How emotions are experienced, expressed, and regulated during conflict.

5.1	Irritation and Frustration	Feeling irritated by repeated expectations and misunderstandings.	1. "I felt annoyed that we argued about my schedule over and over again." 2. "I was frustrated that she couldn't understand my need for flexibility." 3. "I felt very frustrated because they didn't understand my passion." 4. I was really angry at the time... but in the following days, I was also really sad. 5. They oversimplified the idea of my schooling... and that made me really angry.
5.2	Regret and Rationalization	Regretting impulsive reactions and striving for calm, rational communication.	1. "After the fight, I regretted being so aggressive and wanted to express my real thoughts more calmly." 2. "I felt outraged at first, but later felt guilty for expressing myself so strongly."

5.3	Anxiety	Unexpected questioning leading to emotional uncertainty.	1. "When my dad raised the marriage topic, I was caught off guard and felt anxious."
5.4	Helplessness	Strong sense of helplessness due to ineffective communication.	1. "It felt like punching cotton, utterly helpless." 2. "After conversations with my mom, I often felt more frustrated and helpless than before."
5.5	Contemplation	Increased contemplation triggered by conflicts, especially those involving parental expectations	1. "My father's words triggered deeper reflections about my life and future decisions."
5.6	Emotion through behaviors	Participants express emotions indirectly through behavior, using nonverbal cues to show emotions during conflict.	1. I think it's more behavioral 2. When I was in conflict with my parents, some of my behaviors at home would make them know that I was not happy 3. I need to control, I tell them rationally and logically. I feel direct venting of emotions is more like a child's behavior

5.7	Emotions through direct words	Participants express emotions directly through words.	1. Her interference would make me very angry, and so I had a big argument with her 2. So I argued with her with solid reasoning and clear points. 3. It's a bit of a shadow for me, and then I feel a very vivid reenactment of the scene, just like when I was a child. So I couldn't help but have some very emotional reactions to this. For instance, I'm very angry. I felt very helpless again. Then I thought I was already an adult. But still, because of such things, I was repeatedly told what to do and repeatedly questioned, so I was extremely angry. I quickly started this quarrel. 4. I think it's very hard for me not to express my emotions freely in conflicts because I'm already in the conflicts. I can't help but express myself freely. If I'm not expressing my emotions freely, I think it's actually hard to say that it's a conflict.
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6. Culture and values

Definition: How cultural differences between Chinese and Western contexts shape individuals' interpretations and responses to conflict

6.1	Filial Respect	Maintaining respect and responsibility toward parents even when disagreeing.	1. "Because it's my parents, I feel the need to maintain emotional respect even during conflicts." 2. "Parents are the closest people. You can't treat conflicts with them the same way as with peers." 3. "With parents, you have to communicate patiently and respectfully." 4. "I hoped my parents would lower their noble heads and understand me, as they're always perceived as higher in hierarchy." 5. "Even if I disagreed, I still respectfully listened to my parents' concerns." 6. With parents, I show my most vulnerable and real self. 7. You can't be too blunt... saying harsh things could hurt your parents' feelings.
6.2	Cultural Expectation	Cultural expectations leading to anxiety regarding traditional Chinese high family expectation and collectivism	1. "My parents' traditional views about marriage made me feel pressured, although I understood their perspective." 2. Because in my knowledge, my father has always been such a person, because he has very high requirements for himself, so he may have requirements for me, that is, always need to study 3. Usually it's just my dad who thinks I'm a fool. 4. I think it is a more tactful expression... They are older than me, and their experience is more abundant than mine. 5. The relationship with parents won't break it, blood is thicker than water.

6.3	Parental Dominance and Control	Parents' dominance in children's lives affects their sense of autonomy	1. They are too controlling; they're always dominant parents." 2. My dad is more like a supervisor I report to about my daily life.
6.4	Conflict Rooted From Traditional Chinese Value	How Chinese values affect participant's selection of conflict resolutions.	1. The conflicts in the relationship between Chinese children and their parents are actually quite similar. Then I would think that perhaps everyone is experiencing the same problem.... then I just let it be like this. I feel better then. 2. I can't be gay. And when it comes to things like getting married and having children, I think they are actually very similar. They are somewhat different from my expectations and my personal choices.
6.5	Degree of closeness	Conflict may be addressed more directly or lead to relationship reevaluation, depending on the relationship	1. Conflict with parents, you know, no matter what, they will do it for your good or for the good of this family. It is a deeply rooted relationship. The relationship between your parents and you is bound by a bond of kinship. 2. Conflicts among peers are not necessarily for your benefit, or they might be for their own. Moreover, the relationship between you and your peers might be directly severed by a single conflict. If you don't keep in touch with this relationship for a while, the rope will break

Conflict with Peers			
Overarching Code	Subcode	Definition	Coded Text / Examples
1. Causes of Conflict <i>Definition: The background and reasons for the emergence of conflict.</i>			

1.1	Disagreement	Conflicts over differences in thoughts, making joint decisions.	1. "First completing Task A was my priority, while the other insisted on completing Task B. Both sides stuck to their opinions, ultimately leading to a stalemate." 2. When choosing the restaurant, they actually didn't want rice noodles, but they kept quiet and didn't say anything." 3. He unintentionally expressed views that didn't align with mine—particularly feminist values. 4. Regarding future development, there have been some inconsistent ideas and differences. 5. They think it is difficult for them to do something as international students now, but I think it may not be suitable for me.
1.2	Individual Differences	Conflict triggered by contrasting personality traits such as stubbornness.	1. "It was a problem of personality differences." 2. "The other party was very stubborn and unwilling to listen initially." 3. "She is a straightforward person who expresses dissatisfaction directly." 4. "I tend to avoid conflict and was initially scared to face her anger." 5. "He enjoyed staying home playing video games, while I preferred socializing and going out." 6. "Our differing lifestyles frequently led to disagreements about whether village life was boring or enjoyable."

1.3	Social Expectations	Conflict arising from differing expectations about friendship interactions.	1. "She was upset that I didn't invite her to the library." 2. "She thought inviting her every time was a way to show friendship, but I didn't think about it that way."
1.4	Communication Issue	Conflicts caused by a lack of timely, open communication, leading to misunderstandings and accumulated negative feelings.	1. "They were unhappy but didn't explain why, causing the group's atmosphere to become very gloomy." 2. "No one clearly expressed their emotions." 3. "He speaks very directly and concisely, whereas I tend to indirectly describe situations before making my point." 4. "His direct style sometimes confused me, making effective communication challenging." 5. "I prefer immediate communication to reach consensus, but my friends prefer to suppress their opinions without direct expression, resulting in low group morale." 6. "My personality motivates me to openly discuss issues right away." 7. "I prefer openly and straightforwardly addressing issues." 8. "They preferred to withhold their opinions and didn't directly express them... It affected us for several days."

2. Strategic responses

Definition: *Actions taken by participants to manage or resolve conflicts with parents*

2.1	Seeking Third-Party Assistance	Seeking intervention from a neutral figure like a teacher to mediate the conflict.	1. "We reorganized the priority ranking based on the teacher's suggestions." 2. "Through the teacher's neutral perspective, we were able to calm down and rethink the project plans." 3. I vented to my friends or parents... but I basically never said any of it to her. 4. So I asked the professor, and then I checked online by myself to find out how to adjust it better.
2.2	Rational Analysis	Using logic and structured discussion to address differences.	1. "We listed the pros and cons of both proposals." 2. "Public discussion was used to clarify viewpoints more efficiently." 3. If our focus is on solving this problem situation, then this is oriented. I will minimize the emotion.
2.3	Compromise	Reaching an agreement through mutual concessions.	1. "The other party proposed a compromise solution, and I was willing to make concessions too." 2. "We eventually learned to accept each other's differences without insisting on agreement." 3. "We'd simply respond with 'exactly' to each other's opinions, ending the disagreement."
2.4	Immediate Emotional Soothing	Responding quickly to calm the situation and acknowledge the other's feelings.	1. "I immediately tried to soothe her emotions and admitted it was my mistake." 2. "I prioritized calming her down rather than arguing back."

2.5	Open Communication	Resolving the conflict through mutual sharing of feelings and clarification.	1. "We talked it out openly and clarified misunderstandings." 2. "Her direct expression helped me understand her feelings, and I responded actively." 3. We had some public discussions, so we understand each other better. So it is equivalent to resolving this conflict. 4. So soon after I lost my temper, he tried to calm me down. He didn't say anything at that time, just apologized and comforted me. Then, after I calmed down and became calm, he might have started the discussion. 5. The way of expressing oneself candidly is quite effective, because I think many times misunderstandings arise conflicts between friends. 6. In fact, I think in an ideal situation, I would communicate well instead of simply venting my emotions. 7. I think I would say it directly because I believe that having different ideas is, in my eyes, something that doesn't affect friendship at all. 8. We didn't resolve the conflict in the moment... we only addressed it afterward. 9. After we talked, he admitted it was his fault and apologized. 10. I tried to educate him on why his comments were problematic.
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			11. I think as a team, we should finish the goal, so we should sit down and open this matter first, and talk clearly. I can change my part according to their existing model. 12.
2.6	Proactive Adjustment	Taking initiative to prevent potential future conflicts.	1. "I reminded them to download maps beforehand, calculate time accurately, and choose a restaurant everyone would enjoy."
2.7	Direct Clarification	Actively asking questions or clarifying opinions to reduce misunderstandings.	1. "I would carefully double-confirm what they wanted to eat, emphasizing not compromising just for one person."
2.8	Avoidance of Direct Confrontation	Not discussing issues openly during the conflict, instead seeking clarification privately afterward.	1. I learned their opinions through one-on-one conversations rather than direct public discussions." 2. I didn't take the initiative to raise my complaints. 3. I think my personality, I am not a person who likes to initiate conflict. If it is given to a person who is not compatible with me, for example, in personality or behavior, it is not compatible, I'll probably starting to care less about him/her 4. I never talked to her about it... so I chose to endure it. 5. I chose emotional self-protection.
2.9	Manage Emotions	Efforts to regulate one's emotional responses in order to navigate conflict more calmly and preserve the relationship.	1. "I would start from an emotional perspective, trying to avoid direct confrontations." 2. I would start from an emotional perspective, trying to avoid direct confrontations."
3. Motivations behind strategies Definition: Reasons why participants choose certain ways to handle conflict			

3.1	Prioritizing Project Completion	Motivation to ensure the project progresses without delay.	1. "I felt anxious about project progress." 2. "We didn't want small disputes to hinder the overall work." 3. Since we went out together, we needed to respect each other... going with the majority was a possible solution.
3.2	Reducing Misunderstandings	Desire to prevent minor conflicts from escalating.	1. "We clarified each other's viewpoints more efficiently to avoid unnecessary conflicts."
3.3	Avoiding Escalation	Fear of conflict escalation motivated a calming, non-confrontational approach.	1. "I was afraid of conflict and wanted to soothe her emotions immediately." 2. "I didn't want the situation to become more dramatic." 3. I wondered if speaking up directly would make things worse. 4. I was afraid she might do something extreme... so I chose to keep quiet.
3.4	Preserving the Friendship	Motivation to maintain and strengthen the friendship.	1. "I realized that communicating directly would help preserve our friendship." 2. "Understanding her feelings brought us closer afterward." 3. We gradually moved toward mutual tolerance to keep our relationship stable."
3.5	Moral Obligation	Feeling a responsibility to speak up for justice.	1. I felt obligated to explain why his words were offensive.
3.6	Emotional Energy Conservation	Choosing avoidance to preserve energy.	1. If it means saving energy, then avoidance works. 2. "I always felt very tired after conflicts, so I tried to prevent them by communicating indirectly."
3.7	Group Harmony	Attempting to maintain overall harmony and avoid escalation of conflicts	1. "We must choose an option everyone agrees with and enjoys."

3.8	Time Efficiency	Initiating solutions proactively to avoid wasting time.	1. "I could think of alternative solutions, but they were a waste of time; I preferred directly addressing the issue."
3.9	Reciprocal Respect	Highlights the value of mutual respect and refusal to compromise on core values.	1. I personally think respect is mutual, it is a very basic thing. So in fact, most of the time, if I am in an environment where I feel that I am not respected, I will take the initiative to avoid or stay away. 2. So if two of you have different values, like basic social style, and the pursuit of things are different, unless it is a special relationship that cannot be separated, I think everyone has a lot of options, there is no need to compromise or try to change for such a person. 3. Because we have to keep it working until we get a result. We can't say because someone is frustrated, and then not to do it
3.10	Affect other Aspects of Life	Conflict influence participants life significantly	1. I think it's because it has accumulated to a certain extent, and then I think it might have some influence on my life or study state. 2. In a situation where my own study and life conditions are not very good.
3.11	Believe that I didn't do Anything Wrong	Participants think he/she is not responsible for this conflict	1. Then I thought that if I reflected on this myself, I would think that I didn't do anything wrong. But I was under some pressure, and then I would feel very unfair and confused. And because I was angry about it, I might have vented my emotions on the person who made me angry like this. 2. I think before the conflict, I was always in a state of not knowing exactly what was going on

3.12	Feeling of Exclusion	Participants think he/she is excluded, which leads to conflict	1. To put it more directly, his doing this really hurt me and made me feel excluded.
3.13	Unchangeable Principle	Participants' principles were offended, which led to conflict	1. I'm a person who cares a lot about friends. Then I thought there were many principles. I could even change them for my friends, but later I realized that it might be a principle I couldn't change. 2. Hiding something, because I think that in many cases, when I recall it, I would feel that the relationship between the other person and me was not pure enough
4. Relationship repair following conflict <i>Definition: Actions taken by participants to restore trust, understanding, and emotional connection between parents after a conflict</i>			
4.1	Surface-Level Friendship Maintenance	Maintaining minimal contact without deeper emotional bonds.	1. "We barely maintained a surface-level friendship." 2. "The conflict revealed emotional incompatibilities, making future cooperation unlikely." 3. We had more discussions—but I viewed him differently from then on. 4. "Later two couples left, and the remaining three of us stayed together, maintaining relationships on a superficial level." 5. I think to be honest, there is no particular change, because after I know him, I feel that he is someone I can hang out with, but not my close friends.

4.2	Mutual Understanding	Building deeper understanding and emotional bonds post-conflict.	1. "After the conflict, I better understood her needs and how to make her feel valued." 2. "She also understood why I hadn't invited her, and our relationship became closer." 3. After talking it through, it was over... it was just a small episode. 4. "We learned to accommodate each other's preferences over time, becoming more accepting." 5. "Eventually, we simply acknowledged differences briefly, preventing further emotional conflicts." 6. Then I was soon able to understand this matter as well, because his original intention was from a good starting point. So if he explained it to you correctly, it was equivalent to passing through. Maybe indeed, it felt a bit like a misunderstanding. Then it is not a huge irreconcilable conflict. 7. After we resolved this, we remained very good friends. Even now, we are still friends. I am still friends with both A and B 8. Friends still hold a rather important position in my life. Then I feel that a lot of emotions in my life, support and drag on some, well, many very trivial things in daily life, or some happiness is obtained by friends. 9. Maybe a little closer, in the process of making the project, everyone has made it smoothly and has not slowed this pace due to obstructions. Overall, it have been alleviated.
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			10. Maybe because the original solution was to effectively suppress emotions and then deal with it in a more rational way, it may play a certain role in promoting the relationship
4.3	No Repair	No effort made to repair or continue the relationship.	1. When the lease ended... We didn't stay in touch afterward. 2. Eventually, we just grew apart.
4.5	Cautious Interaction	Becoming more cautious in communication, reserving personal opinions to reduce direct interaction.	1. "I became more cautious and careful speaking with them, tending to keep personal opinions to myself."
4.6	Emotional Detachment	Creating emotional distance post-conflict as a protective mechanism.	1. "It made me rethink how to interact with this person in the future."
5. Emotional and psychological mechanisms <i>Definition: How emotions are experienced, expressed, and regulated during conflict.</i>			
5.1	Frustration	Frustration resulting from disagreement and lack of understanding.	1. "I felt very frustrated because my plan was not accepted." 2. I felt offended and angry. 3. I just felt sad—the friendship was deteriorating... 4. "Their indirectness and silence made me feel frustrated."
5.2	Anxiety	Feeling worried about task delays and outcomes.	1. "I was worried about the project's progress being delayed." 2. "I felt nervous and anxious, unsure if we were communicating effectively or on the same page."

5.3	Emotional Regulation	Transitioning from emotional reactions to calm, logical discussion.	1. "After calming down for a few days, I initiated a rational discussion." 2. At first, I felt really sad or helpless... but if it could be resolved later, then it was fine. 3. I usually withheld my true emotions during conflicts to avoid worsening the situation."
5.4	Fear and Avoidance (at the start)	Initial emotional reaction characterized by fear and desire to avoid conflict.	1. "I felt afraid and wanted to escape the situation when she got upset."
5.5	Empathy and Guilt (during resolution)	Gradual shift toward empathy and feelings of guilt.	1. "After hearing her reasons, I empathize with her and felt guilty for not inviting her." 2. She screamed very loudly... it was terrifying, I really didn't dare speak to her.
5.6	Emotional Relief (after reconciliation)	Positive emotions following the resolution of the conflict.	1. "After resolving it, I felt happy and harmonious again."
5.7	Nonverbal Anger expression	Uses non-verbal cues to express frustration.	1. No, to be honest, I think I was acting very passive aggressive 2. If I really feel, well, not happy, I am not comfortable in such an environment, and I will express them in an very obvious way, that is, use some expressions or attitudes to do things to express my negative emotions 3. I think I would use words like anger and childish to describe it
5.8	Confusion	Didn't understand what happened in that moment.	1. "I felt confused and momentarily lost control of the conversation."

5.9	Verbal Anger Expression	Uses verbal cues to express frustration.	1. Then. So one day, it was a bit like an outbreak. 2. I wasn't using it as a means to resolve the conflict. In fact, I think at that time, I might have been more like venting my emotions, but perhaps because of the idea that we were still willing to be friends. So it's as if I were just having a sudden outburst. So I said this to vent my emotions. 3. In fact, it was freer than I thought. Because I think many of my words at that time might not have been rational. Indeed, because I didn't do this with the intention of resolving the conflict originally, I might have had an emotional outburst, and then I might have also said some irrational words. Then I might be asking about the reason for this matter. In fact, I'm more inclined to question the other party's attitude. 4. I think actually, at the moment I said it, I felt much better later on.
5.10	Stunned	Initially feeling shocked and speechless due to a lack of understanding.	1. "My initial reaction was stunned; I was speechless." 2. "My initial feeling was shock; I couldn't immediately process why someone would think differently."

5.11	Sadness	The cause of conflict brought huge feeling of sadness to the participants	1. Then it made me feel very sad. In a relationship of three people, I think, although rationally speaking, everyone has different personalities and thus different boundaries and degrees of closeness in the relationship, perhaps for me at that time, it still made me feel a bit uncomfortable. 2. You will sense some of the other person's indifference and thus doubt yourself. In fact, at that time, it might have been like he only concealed this one thing from me, but in other aspects, we still played together. However, during the process of playing together, I might have felt some very subtle differences brought about by this incident
5.12	Suppression	Consciously inhibits the expression of their emotions	1. I feel I cannot express my emotions freely to a certain extent, because I want to make the project work well. 2. Maybe it stabilized my emotions. They restrained themselves and realized their mistakes.
6. Culture and values <i>Definition: How cultural and gender differences shape individuals' interpretations and responses to conflict</i>			
6.1	Directness in Peer Communication	Emphasis on efficient, open discussion over maintaining harmony.	1. "With peers, it's better to be direct — if it doesn't work, it's fine to part ways." 2. "When doing tasks with peers, I prefer direct confrontation and third-party judgment if necessary." 3. "My personality motivates me to openly discuss issues right away." 4. "I prefer openly and straightforwardly addressing issues."

6.2	Harmony Preservation	Preference for maintaining interpersonal harmony rather than direct confrontation.	1. "I tried my best to soothe her emotions because I hate conflicts." 2. "I felt it was better to calmly resolve things than to argue aggressively."
6.3	Gender Norm Sensitivity	Reacting strongly to gender-related issues.	1. Especially if it's a gender issue, I react more strongly.
6.4	Discomfort with Emotional Expression	Suppressing emotional confrontation due to discomfort.	1. Expressing emotions felt uncomfortable. 2. "I naturally adopted an indirect style to avoid direct confrontations."
6.5	Value Discrepancy	Mismatch between an individual's personal values and the values held by others.	1. Maybe there's a difference in communication. Everyone has different styles, and then they may accidentally speak in a way that is not so nice when they want to express something.